MOUNTAIN BIKES · 6 MIN READ

Wheels, forks, drivetrains and brakes

Wheel size

- **29 inch** rolls over rocks and roots more easily and holds speed. It is the standard for adults.
- **27.5 inch** is quicker to turn and suits smaller riders.
- Merida tells you in the name: **Big Nine** is 29, **Big Seven** is 27.5. Kona and Polygon listings say 29ER or 27.5ER.
- Trek Marlin matches wheel size to frame size, so smaller frames come with smaller wheels.

Fork

- **Coil fork**: a steel spring inside. Heavier and basic. Found on entry bikes.
- **Air fork**: lighter, and you set it to the rider's weight with a shock pump.
- **Lockout**: a lever that stiffens the fork for tarmac and smooth climbs.

Drivetrain

Modern MTBs use **1x**: one chainring in front and a wide cassette at the back. One shifter, no front derailleur, fewer dropped chains.

BRAND	LADDER, ENTRY TO TOP
Shimano	Tourney, Altus, Acera, Alivio, Deore, SLX, XT, XTR
SRAM Eagle (12-speed)	SX, NX, GX, X0, XX

CUES is Shimano's newer family that is replacing the lower and middle groups. It is built to last longer.

Brakes and other parts

- **Hydraulic disc brakes** are the norm. Bigger rotors (180 or 203 mm) give more stopping power than 160 mm.
- **Dropper post**: a seatpost that drops with a handlebar lever so the rider can move freely on descents.
- **Tubeless**: no inner tube. Sealant inside closes small punctures and the tyre runs at lower pressure for grip.
- **Thru-axle**: a thick axle that threads into the frame. Stiffer and safer than quick release.

Remember these

- Big Nine is 29 inch, Big Seven is 27.5 inch.
- Air forks are lighter and adjust to rider weight. Coil forks are entry level.
- Shimano: Tourney, Altus, Acera, Alivio, Deore, SLX, XT, XTR.
- Dropper post, tubeless and thru-axles are the upgrades trail riders ask about.